

Chicago Tribune



QUESTIONS? CALL 1-800-TRIBUNE

THURSDAY, DECEMBER 25, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



REVELING IN GLORY OF HOMETOWN POPE

Leo XIV's historic rise forges special Vatican connections for Chicago

By Angie Leventis Lourgos | Chicago Tribune

The experience was almost surreal. A Chicago priest climbed aboard the iconic popemobile alongside the Holy Father, the two longtime friends traversing the cobblestone plaza of St. Peter's Square at the Vatican as a crowd of tens of thousands cheered and waved. During an October trip to Rome, the Rev. John Lydon of Hyde Park reunited with his former roommate, newly named Pope Leo XIV, a Chicago native whose historic election earlier this year marked the first American-born pontiff.

They shared a private talk in Leo's apartment, reminiscing about their time together years ago as missionaries in Peru. The pope invited Lydon to join him for a ride in the famed popemobile, an electric Mercedes Benz custom-made for public appearances, after Mass on Sunday.

"It was very emotional," Lydon recalled during a recent interview with the Tribune. "It was overwhelming, just to see the love the people have for the pope. Screaming his name. Screaming what town they were from and what country they were from and waving their flags and a million cellphones taking pictures."

The Chicago area erupted in celebration May 8 at news that Robert Francis Prevost — born in Bronzeville and raised in south suburban Dolton — was chosen as the 267th pope and leader of an estimated 1.4 billion Catholics worldwide.

Chicago has reveled in the glory of a hometown pope who cast a divine light on the city, elevating its status on the international stage and reigniting the faith of many locals.

A clip of students at Our Lady of Mount Carmel Academy in Lakeview holding their own mock papal conclave went viral in May. Then the boys and girls, dressed as cardinals and a pope, traveled to Vatican City to meet the pontiff in person

Above: Pope Leo XIV blesses the crowd with holy water during his installation Mass in St. Peter's Square on May 18 at the Vatican.
BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

in October.

The Chicago White Sox unveiled an art installation at Rate Field near Section 140, Row 19, Seat 2, commemorating where the man who would become pope famously sat during Game 1 of the 2005 World Series, a tribute to the South Sider's devotion as a fan.

Local restaurants crafted pontifical-themed menu items including a limited-time Portillo's sandwich dubbed "The Leo," described as "divinely seasoned Italian beef, baptized in gravy, and topped with your choice of sweet or hot

Turn to Pope, Page 4

Ukraine open to pullback of troops

Zelenskyy would make move if Putin agrees to demilitarized zone

By Samya Kullab
Associated Press

KYIV, Ukraine — Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said he would be willing to withdraw troops from the country's eastern industrial heartland as part of a plan to end Russia's war, if Moscow also pulls back and the area becomes a demilitarized zone monitored by international forces.

The proposal offered another potential compromise on control of the Donbas region, which has been a major sticking point in peace negotiations.

Zelenskyy said the U.S. proposed the creation of a "free economic zone," which he said should be demilitarized. But it was unclear what that idea would mean for governance or development of the region.

A similar arrangement could be possible for the area around the Zaporizhzhia nuclear power plant, which is currently under Russian control, Zelenskyy said. He said any peace plan would need to be put to a referendum.

Zelenskyy spoke to reporters Tuesday to describe an overarching 20-point plan that negotiators from Ukraine and the U.S. hammered out in Florida in recent days, though he said many details are still being discussed.

Russia has given no indication that it will agree to any kind of withdrawal from land it has seized. In fact, Moscow has insisted that Ukraine relinquish the remaining territory it still holds in the Donbas — an ultimatum that Ukraine has rejected. Russia has captured most of Luhansk and about 70% of Donetsk — the two areas that make up the Donbas.

Asked about the plan, Kremlin spokesperson Dmitry Peskov

Turn to Ukraine, Page 9

INSIDE

Determination pays off for NU safety

Northwestern's Robert Fitzgerald, shaped by his dad's memory, worked his way from scout team to All-Big Ten. **Chicago Sports**

BETHLEHEM AT CHRISTMAS:

Thousands flocked to Manger Square after two years of subdued celebrations. **Nation & World**

Bison return to Kane County after 200 years

Marks crucial step for conservation, Indigenous connection

By Adriana Pérez
Chicago Tribune

From their cozy homes in suburban Burlington, children curiously watch their new neighbors through windows and brainstorm nicknames.

Earlier this month, with their distinctive brown fur, big heads, short horns and back hump, a small herd of six American buffalo — the largest land mammals in the country — exited a trailer and took their first steps on 38 acres of prairie restored by the Kane County Forest Preserve District, 60 miles northwest of downtown



A bison in Burlington Prairie Forest Preserve in Burlington Township on Monday. Six American bison have been introduced into the preserve.

E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Chicago. It's the first time in over two centuries that bison have called the county home.

Inches of snow had piled on the ground, and conservationists had waited for hours in the brutal cold for the animals to show up.

The move was a rematriation, a return of missing relatives, according to Jay Young, co-ex-

ecutive director of the American Indian Center of Chicago, which owns the animals in the collaborative conservation effort.

"I don't like using the word ownership, because that's not a Native or Indigenous worldview," Young said. "We are the stewards

Turn to Bison, Page 2

Last chance to see home decked out for 'Swiftmas'

Owners don't plan Taylor Swift-themed decorations next year

By Carolyn Stein
Naperville Sun

Are you ready for it?

Swiftmas has returned to Naperville with a display that will leave you feeling enchanted ... for the last time.

That's right, this is the last year the family at 1228 Atlas Lane plans on decking out their home for Swiftmas.

"We're at the end of an era with all our Taylor stuff," said Amy Scott, who owns the house with her husband Brian.

Their two daughters, Emily and Rebecca, are crucial for building the display but since they are now home less often, it's become a big endeavor for the couple.

"We're not sure if we want to still do big displays but it's the last year for this theme at least," Scott said.

But before they shake it off and switch up their decorations, the Scotts decided to bejewel their house one last time.

"People come from all over to see our lights, which is shocking to us," Scott, a teacher at Still Middle School in Aurora, said. "People are driving an hour, two hours, just to come in and see our display. And so we didn't want to just stop cold turkey."

The Swiftmas story: It's been a tradition for the family to go all out with their Christmas decorations, but Scott said the idea to do a Taylor Swift theme came after she saw the Eras Tour concert movie in 2023. Decorations that first year included a Taylor Swift

Turn to Decorations, Page 3

